

Rebel Human Rights Abuses During Civil Wars: Introducing the Rebel Human Rights Violation Dataset

Introduction

Despite being bound by international humanitarian law to respect non-combatants (Slim, 2010), rebel groups commit a wide range of human rights abuses during civil wars. The International Criminal Court and ad hoc tribunals have prosecuted rebel commanders and soldiers for violations of laws of armed conflict. With some important exceptions, however, existing research focuses primarily on rebel use of violence that has the deliberate aim of inflicting *lethal* harm against non-combatants, such as massacres, indiscriminate bombings, and terrorist attacks. This emphasis on lethal violations, based in part on the availability of cross-national data, has the effect of overlooking the many non-lethal ways in which rebel groups violate the rights of civilian populations.

We introduce the Rebel Human Rights Violations (RHRV) dataset that measures a much wider range of abuses committed by rebels. It includes episodes of lethal violence but also detention, forced recruitment, property damage, torture, sexual violence, forced displacement, and the restriction of movement. Building on existing projects that measure violations of physical integrity rights by governments, we use annual human rights reports issued by the U.S. Department of State and Amnesty International to systematically document the occurrence and scale of these abuses by rebel groups for all civil wars in each year from 1990 to 2018. The dataset provides the first systematic, cross-conflict description of multiple human rights violations by rebel forces during civil wars.

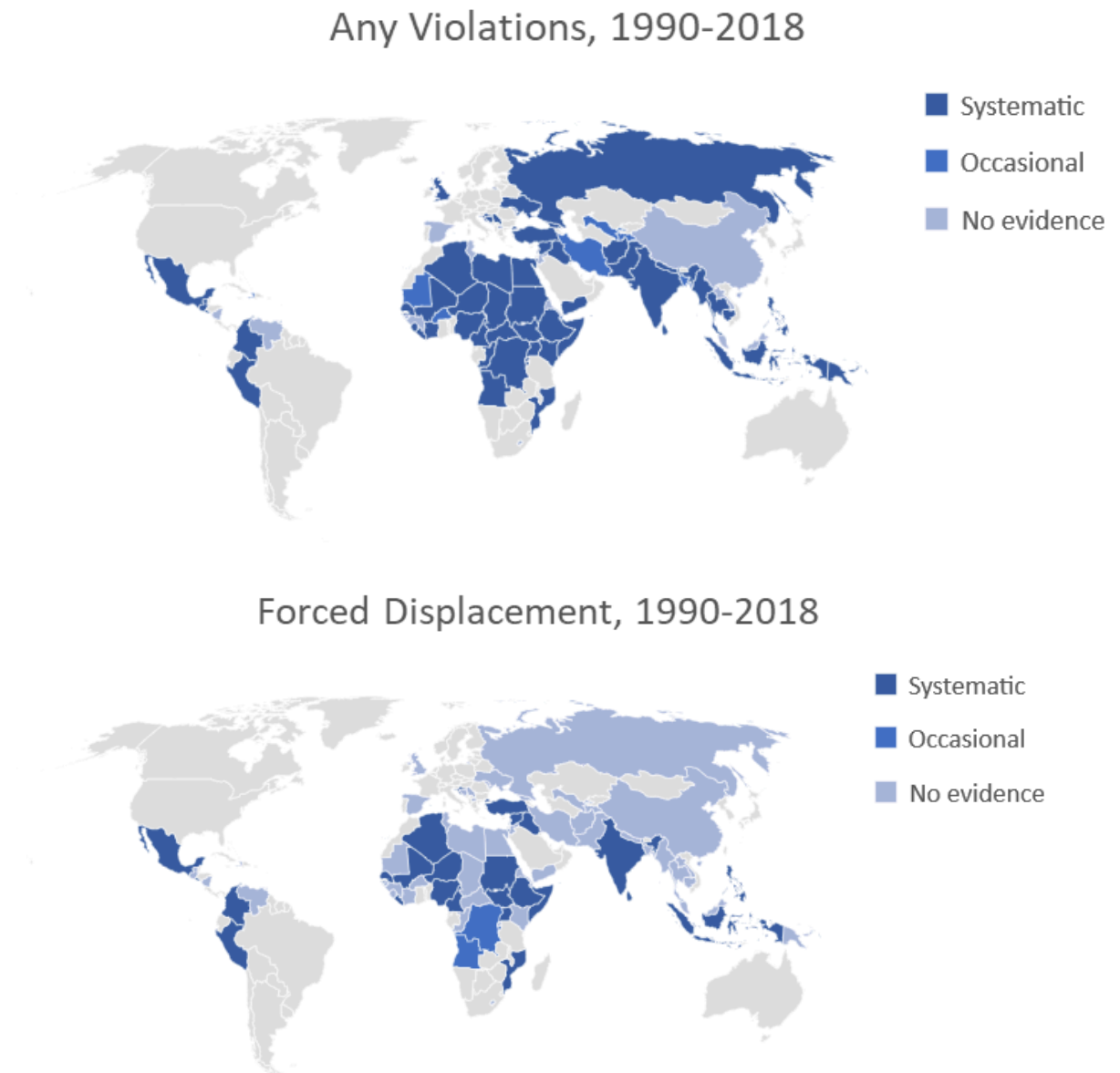
Researchers can use the RHRV dataset to address multiple questions regarding civil war violence. Descriptive statistics reported here indicate that there are noticeable differences across civil wars and over time; some rebel groups regularly commit a wide range of abuses, others may develop “repertoires” of violence that emphasize some abuses more than others (Gutiérrez-Sanín and Wood, 2017), and other groups appear to alter the types of human rights abuses they commit as conflict continues for longer periods. The data can be used to systematically investigate the degree to which rebels engage in abuses as complements or substitutes, along the lines of similar analyses of state abuses (Fariss and Schnakenberg, 2014). The dataset can be used to test theories at the rebel organization or conflict dyad level of analysis about the conditions under which rebels abuse civilians, including the relative influences of battlefield outcomes, political goals and ideologies, external actors, and international humanitarian law.

Figure 1 demonstrates how some of the data can be visualized broadly at the country level.¹ The first map shows the peak level of any of the eight rebel human rights violations recorded in the dataset by country. For countries with multiple rebel groups, the maximum value among all groups and all violations is used. Most countries experiencing conflict saw at least one form of systematic human rights violation by rebels during the period 1990-2018. The second map, however, depicts a single type of violation by rebel groups: forced displacement. Systematic levels of forced displacement only occurred in 26 countries during the time period; in fact, there was no evidence of forced displacement by rebels in the majority of countries experiencing conflict. The information available in the dataset can also complement studies that

¹ Map plots powered by Bing © Australian Bureau of Statistics, GeoNames, Microsoft, Navinfo, TomTom, Wikipedia

use more fine-grained spatio-temporal data to analyze conflict dynamics in single case studies, allowing researchers to investigate if the same patterns exist across multiple rebel groups.

Figure 1: Peak Levels of Human Rights Violations by Rebel Groups



Contemporary research on civil wars has sought to explain why rebels abuse civilian populations, generally treating this behavior as an outcome variable. Explanations include how rebels fund their activities through external support, natural resource wealth, and criminal activities (Weinstein, 2007; Salehyan, Sirosky, and Wood, 2014; Walsh et al., 2019); the degree to which combatants control territory and have reliable information about the political allegiances of civilians (Kalyvas, 2006); intra-organizational concerns, including rebel leaders' ability to discipline and control their soldiers (Hoover Green, 2016), recruitment needs (Cohen, 2016) and use of foreign fighters (Doctor, 2021); the use of violence to weaken the authorities' popular support (Fjelde and Hultman, 2013); and the relative power and military strategies of the combatants (Stanton, 2016; Wood, 2010).

These works develop general explanations of rebel violence that they test with data from many civil conflicts. The most common sources of such data are the Uppsala Conflict Data Program's (UCDP) Georeferenced Event Dataset (GED; Sundberg and Melander, 2013; Croicu and Sundberg, 2017), which includes data from the UCDP One-Sided Violence (OSV) dataset (Eck and Hultman, 2007); the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project (ACLED; see Raleigh et al., 2010); and the Global Terrorism Dataset (GTD; see Lafree and Dugan, 2007). All these datasets record the time period, location, and perpetrators of acts of violence based on a wide range of sources, including media reports and investigations by non-governmental and international organizations. They differ primarily in terms of the types of violent acts they record. The GED includes only lethal acts of violence that result in at least one death of a combatant or civilian. ACLED includes similar data, but also measures changes in territory among combatants as well as riots, protests, and similar politically relevant events. As its name

suggests, the GTD includes only events that meet its definition of terrorism: “the threatened or actual use of illegal force and violence by a non-state actor to attain a political, economic, religious, or social goal through fear, coercion, or intimidation.”

The GED, ACLED, and GTD have proven very useful in extending our understanding of civil war dynamics. However, by focusing primarily on violent events that might or might not result directly in the death of non-combatants, they provide limited information about the entire range of human rights violations that rebel forces commit. This has led to the recent development of datasets that measure specific human rights violations beyond killings. The Sexual Violence in Conflict (SVAC) dataset (Cohen and Nordås 2014), for example, uses manual text coding from human rights reports by the U.S. State Department and Amnesty International to measure one non-lethal form of political violence. Along similar lines, the Child Soldier Data Set (CSDS; Haer and Böhmelt, 2016) provides indicators of the use of child soldiers by rebel groups; subsequent versions focus specifically on the use of girl soldiers (Haer and Böhmelt, 2018) and on the forcible recruitment of children (Haer, Faulkner, and Whitaker, 2020).

These datasets have been used to test theories explaining rebel engagement in individual forms of non-lethal violence, especially sexual violence and the use of child soldiers. Using the SVAC data, Cohen (2016) finds evidence that armed groups that rely on abduction or press-ganging to recruit fighters use sexual violence to create unit cohesion. Whitaker, Walsh, and Conrad (2019) show that rebels that extort natural resource production engage in sexual violence more frequently, while groups that smuggle natural resources limit the use of this form of violence. Tynes and Early (2013) analyze how structural variables such as the length of a conflict and combatants’ relative capabilities influence group decisions to use child soldiers. And

Haer, Faulkner, and Whitaker (2020) find that rebels that profit from natural resources are more likely to forcibly recruit child soldiers. These studies usefully expand our knowledge of the drivers of rebel human rights abuses beyond killings to explain the dynamics of sexual violence and recruitment of children. But focusing on individual forms of abuse is distinct from examining overall patterns of violence committed by rebel forces and how these patterns may shift in response to international pressure or conflict developments.²

The RHRV dataset we introduce here builds on these important data collection efforts while measuring a much wider range of human rights abuses by rebel forces.³ This is important because rebels frequently rely on forms of violence that do not directly aim to kill their targets. Mass rape has been committed in parts of Africa by rebels who do not engage in mass killings (Gutiérrez-Sanín and Wood, 2017, 22, citing Nordås, 2011). Rebels can engage in large-scale property destruction, such as the burning of villages or crops, that only incidentally kills civilians but that inflicts considerable harm on non-combatants nonetheless. Some rebels also frequently use violence to coerce civilians to join their ranks; here the threat of force is used to change the target's behavior, but the goal is not to kill the target. Gutiérrez-Sanín and Wood (2017, 21) observe that “violence against civilians during war varies in ways much richer than that emphasized in most of the literature. Many scholars focus on lethal violence without consistently specifying whether the organization engages in non-lethal forms of violence.” The causes and consequences of lethal and non-lethal violence may differ in important ways. It is difficult to

² Stanton (2016) considers a wider range of abuses, although her analysis focuses primarily on the systematic and large-scale use of some forms of lethal and non-lethal violence by combatants, including property destruction, indiscriminate bombing and shelling, and forced displacement.

³ The appendix includes a statistical comparison of relevant RHRV variables to data from the SVAC and one-sided violence (OSV) datasets.

know if this is the case, however, as scholars lack systematic data on forms of violence that may not be intended to cause the death of their targets.

The Rebel Human Rights Violations dataset systematically identifies allegations of the types and degrees of lethal and non-lethal violence committed by rebel groups during civil wars. It builds on similar efforts to measure a wide range of human rights violations committed by governments, specifically the Political Terror Scales (PTS; see Gibney and Wood 2010) and the Cingranelli-Richards Human Rights Data Project (CIRI; see Cingranelli and Richards 2010). Those efforts both rely on regular assessments of the human rights situation in countries around the world produced by the U.S. Department of State and the non-governmental organizations Amnesty International and Human Rights Watch. While the PTS measures the overall level of abuse of rights in a country, the CIRI project identifies allegations of specific abuses such as torture and political imprisonment. In the next section, we describe how we use the latter approach to identify and measure abuses of human rights by rebel groups.

While non-governmental organizations, the media, and other groups provide useful reporting about violence and human rights violations, they may lack the interest in or capability to investigate or report all violations (Davenport, 2009). Any dataset based on such reporting, including the one we introduce here, is more accurately described as a dataset of allegations of human rights violations committed by rebel groups rather than a ground-truth accounting of such violations. It is possible, for example, that some conflicts receive less attention from reporting sources such as the State Department and Amnesty International, leading to the under-reporting of rebel human rights violations. For this reason, we describe observations for which our underlying sources do not report rebel human rights violations as “no allegations” rather than “no

violation.” In this sense, the RHRV dataset is similar to other efforts to collect data on human rights abuses by states and rebels (e.g. Cingranelli and Richards, 2010; Cohen and Nordås, 2014; Eck and Hultman, 2007; Haer and Böhmelt, 2018; LaFree and Dugan, 2007; Wood and Gibney, 2010). Researchers should be cognizant of this possibility when using the RHRV and similar datasets. While the primary purpose of this paper is to introduce and describe the dataset, future research could address questions about reporting coverage. For example, researchers might build on the RHRV dataset to understand how monitoring practices developed by different governmental, non-governmental, and international organizations to document and address abuses by state actors influence the likelihood that rebel abuses also are monitored, and how such monitoring might vary across time and space (Tayler, 2011). Similarly, researchers might apply recent innovations in latent variable analysis and Bayesian methods to measure uncertainty and identify biases in reporting (Fariss, 2019).

Identifying Rebel Human Rights Violations in Civil Wars

Inspired by the PTS and CIRI projects, the RHRV dataset compiles information on human rights violations committed by rebel groups around the world in each year from 1990 to 2018. Data are drawn from the U.S. State Department *Country Reports on Human Rights Practices*, which provide qualitative assessments of the human rights abuses committed by state and non-state actors within each country, and annual country reports from Amnesty International. Below, we report findings from the data coded from the U.S. State Department reports; a comparison with and identical analysis for the Amnesty International data are reported in the appendix. In short, these reporting sources lead to very similar data with some exceptions for displacement and movement restriction.

Amnesty International stopped producing most annual country reports after 2017,⁴ while the State Department continued to produce its annual reports, allowing us to code data from 2018 from this source (and to code additional years in future research). The State Department reports are longer and more detailed, on average, than those produced by Amnesty International, are informed by input from Amnesty International and other human rights non-governmental organizations, and also rely on reporting by the department's foreign service officers and other elements of the U.S. government. These factors might reduce reporting bias compared to reports produced by Amnesty International, although they are unlikely to eliminate it entirely. The State Department and Amnesty International annual reports have been found to produce similar assessments of governments' human rights practices, especially after 1990 when our data begin (Poe, Carey, and Vazquez, 2001).

Unlike the PTS and CIRI projects, we focus specifically on abuses committed by non-state rebel groups. The unit of analysis is the conflict dyad-year, and the sample of observations is based on dyadic armed conflict data maintained by the Uppsala Conflict Data Program (UCDP; see Harbom, Melander and Wallensteen, 2008). The data for rebel groups in each country were coded by teams of two undergraduate students supervised by a graduate student and a faculty member. There were multiple teams of coders. Each student worked alone, and did not discuss their coding decisions with others. The students were coded only the information provided in the relevant human rights reports. Students who were coding rebel groups in the same country then met with their supervisor, who arbitrated and reconciled any

⁴ Amnesty International did produce limited annual regional reports after 2017 and the annual country reports started again for most countries in 2021.

coding discrepancies. The codebook detailing this coding process and variable definitions is included in the appendix.

The dataset includes a series of ordinal variables that indicate if and how often the rebel group in each conflict dyad engaged in a particular violation each year. Each variable represents an ordinal frequency according to the following scheme: if the variable is coded as “0,” the reports include no allegations that the rebel group engaged in that violation during the given year. If the variable is coded as “1,” the rebel group is considered to have engaged in that particular violation “occasionally” or “infrequently.” If the variable is coded as “2” (the highest value possible), there is evidence suggesting the group engaged in the violation “frequently” or “systematically.” Coders looked for these qualitative frequency terms, but the reports sometimes include a specific number of violations. When such numbers are provided, the value “2” is used to denote violations that affected 50 or more victims, while “1” designates 1-49 victims. One of the most challenging aspects of the coding process was distinguishing between violations coded as a “1” and those coded as a “2.” Although coders were trained on how to make these distinctions, the final data can be aggregated in a way that mitigates these concerns. Violations coded as “1” and “2” can be collapsed to create a binary variable indicating whether there was evidence of the violation in question or not. The dataset also includes the specific language from the human rights reports used to measure each variable. This allows other researchers to make their own assessments of our coding decisions. Drawing on these excerpts, future researchers could use natural language processing to extract measures of rebel human rights violations from subsequent reports.

The dataset includes eight violations of civil and political rights: unlawful or arbitrary killings; detention and disappearances; torture; property violations; forcible recruitment; sexual violence; forced displacement; and movement restriction. Details on the definitions of these variables and coding procedures are provided in the appendix. A key distinction for all violations coded in the data is that they are not combat-related. Many human rights violations occur in the context of armed conflict. For instance, civilians are often killed as an unintentional consequence of battle (i.e., “collateral damage”). The RHRV dataset does not include such violations. We focus exclusively on human rights violations that occur outside of direct combat situations.

We consider rebel groups to have engaged in *unlawful or arbitrary killings* when they deliberately kill civilians outside of the context of armed conflict. Under most circumstances, these killings are politically-motivated, as this is the kind of violence that is most often highlighted by the State Department reports. Again, combat-related deaths and the unintentional killing of civilians are not included in this category. The second category, *disappearances and detentions*, includes any forced disappearance or abduction of victims, including political kidnappings. This does not include individuals who were “disappeared” or abducted in the context of armed conflict. The category of *torture* captures the intentional infliction of mental or physical pain on individuals in the custody of the rebel group. Such violence can have multiple purposes, including information-gathering or simple physical degradation. The fourth category, *property violations*, includes a wide range of activities, from poisoning water wells to attacks on cellphone towers. The common link in these activities is that they all involve the rebel group’s interference with, or the destruction of, personal property. In most cases, the destruction is

intended to punish or create fear in local communities. Combat-related (tactical) destruction of property and interference with property motivated by profit are not included in this category.

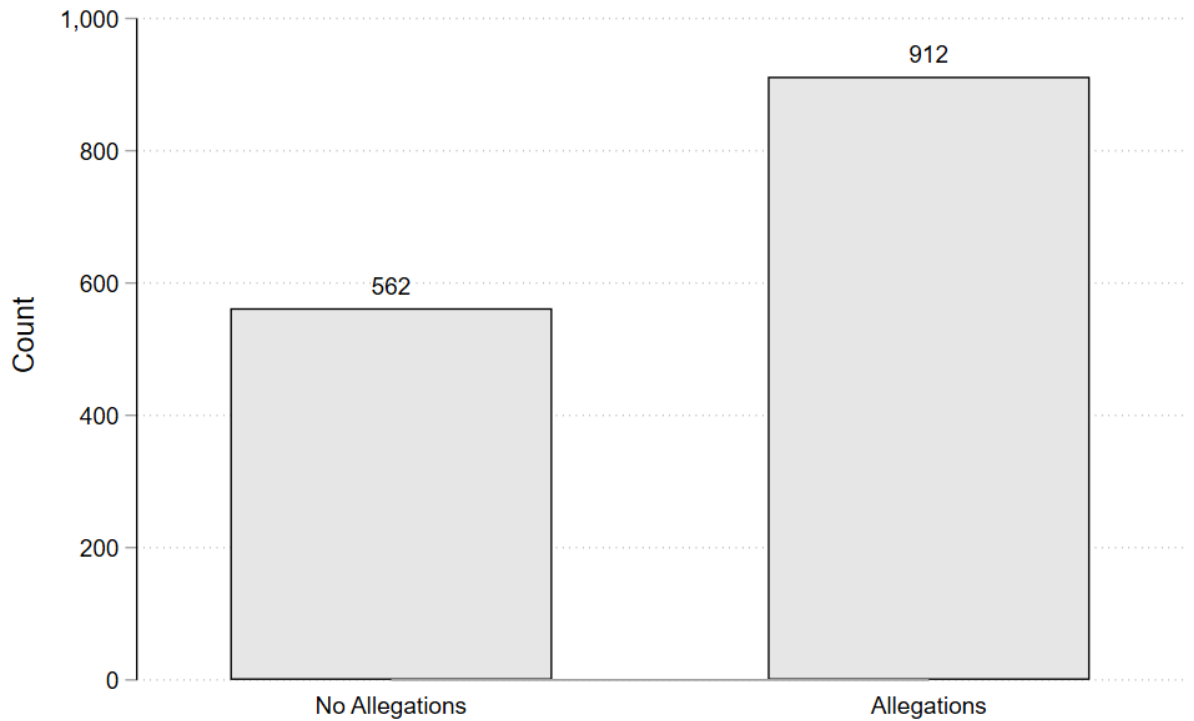
The variable *forcible recruitment* involves rebel groups forcing individuals to perform work for the organization against their will. This includes forcible recruitment of soldiers as well as general labor. Forced recruitment of child soldiers and forced labor in the extraction of natural resources are both included in the category. *Sexual violence* includes the intentional infliction of mental or physical pain of a sexual nature. This includes instances of rape, many forms of sexual assault, and genital mutilation.⁵ *Forced displacement* measures if rebels use force or the threat of force to cause civilians to flee their neighborhoods. *Movement restriction* involves the deliberate prevention of individuals leaving their homes, neighborhoods, or towns for more than a brief period of time. Table 1 illustrates how we turned the text in State Department reports into these ordinal variables. The table lists the name of the rebel group, the government it opposed, the year of the violation, and the text from the report that was used to code the violation as systematic (a value of “2” in the dataset).

⁵ In our measurement scheme, sexual violence is a subset of torture; all reports of sexual violence were also recorded as incidents of torture.

Table 1: Examples of Text Used to Code Systematic Violations

Violation	Rebels	Government	Year	Text
Killings	AFRC	Sierra Leone	1998	Throughout the year, AFRC and RUF rebels committed numerous egregious abuses, including brutal killings, severe mutilations, and deliberate dismemberments, in a widespread campaign of terror against the civilian population.
Torture	LRR	Ukraine	2015	Separatists systematically engaged in abductions, torture, and unlawful detention.
Detention	Boko Haram	Nigeria	2015	Boko Haram insurgents kidnapped hundreds of civilians during their multiple attacks in the Far North Region, including Double, Waza, Amchide, Tchakamari, and Blame, among other districts.
Property	ELN	Colombia	2001	Guerrillas, usually the ELN, caused massive damage to the country's power industry and increases in electricity rates for consumers. ELN sabotage in December 2000 and FARC attacks in March left several towns in the Uraba region without electricity for weeks at a time, causing economic and health problems.
Forced Recruitment	Serbian Republic	Bosnia	1995	Reliable sources reported wide-scale use of prisoners for forced labor on the front lines by the Bosnian Serbs.
Sexual Violence	Seleka	Central African Republic	2013	Armed men reportedly belonging to the Seleka perpetrated 140 rapes.
Forced Displacement	Kashmir Insurgents	India	2013	According to 2013 IDMC statistics, regional conflicts had displaced at least 526,000 persons, including several thousand Kashmiri Hindus driven from their homes by antigovernment insurgents.
Movement Restriction	IS	Iraq	2016	The government, the PMF, and Da'esh all established roadblocks that impeded the flow of humanitarian assistance to communities in need.

Figure 2: Rebel Human Rights Violations, 1990-2018



Patterns of Rebel Human Rights Violations in Civil War

Rebels commit at least one form of human rights abuse in over half of the dyad years in the dataset. Figure 2 counts the number of dyad years in which the source documents do and do not contain allegations of any of the eight violations. Rebel groups are more likely than not to commit *some* type of human rights abuse during civil wars. Looking at global patterns across the different types of violations and over time, however, rebel violations of human rights are less frequent than might be expected. Figure 3 plots the number of conflict dyad-years in which rebels commit each of the human rights abuses described in the dataset. “No allegation” means that there was no evidence in the State Department report that the rebel group engaged in that form of violation. Fewer than half of groups commit each violation, with the exception of killings. It is possible that this reflects reporting bias in the State Department's annual human

rights reports. It may be that extrajudicial killings are more frequently investigated and reported and are thus more likely to be reported than other violations. However, among rebels that do violate human rights, a larger fraction engages in frequent or systematic abuses. This could be because more systematic abuses are more likely to be captured in the source reports. Additionally, there is variation over time in each violation as depicted in Figure 4, which shows the percentage of dyads in which rebel groups engaged in each type of human rights abuse.

Figure 3: Specific Violations, 1990-2018

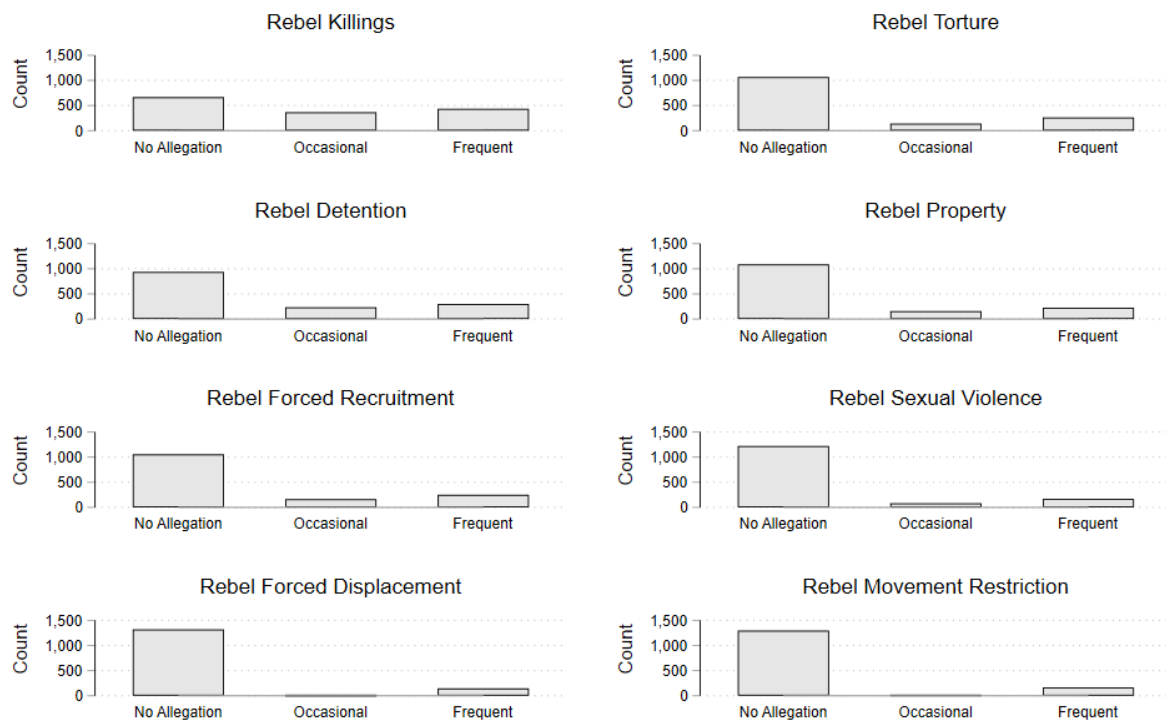


Figure 4: Violations Per Year, 1990-2018

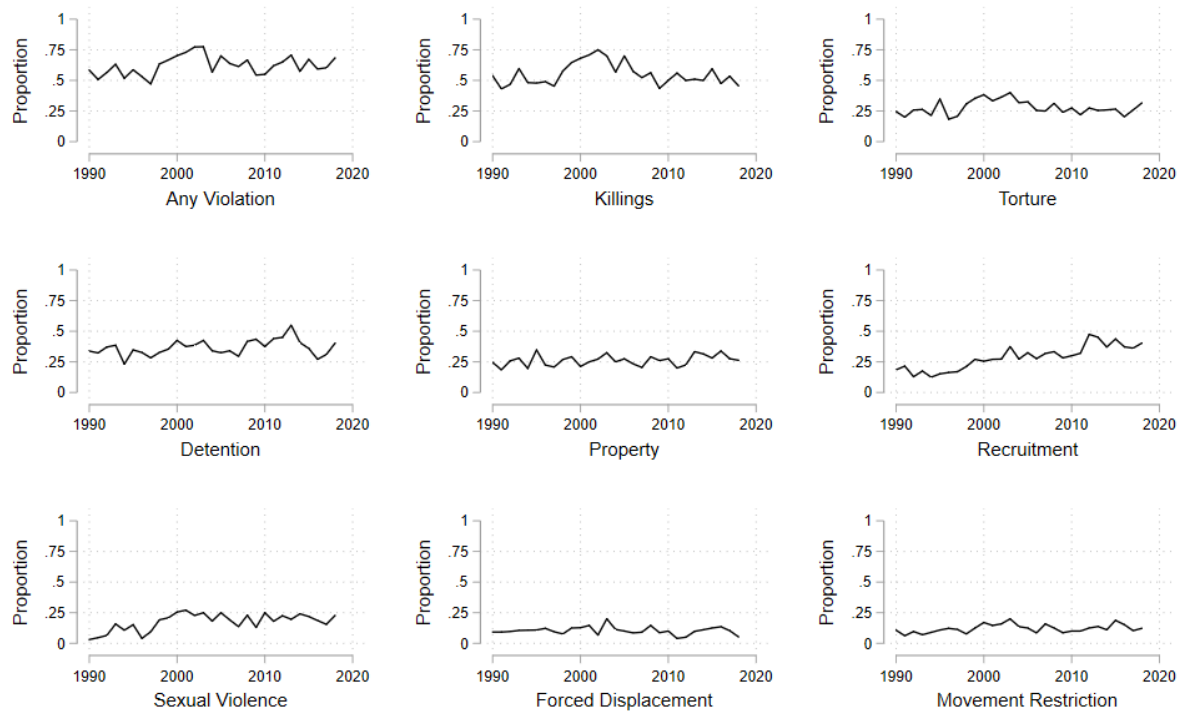


Table 2 shows the polychoric correlations among the variables. The strongest correlation is between torture and sexual violence, which is expected since the categories are not mutually exclusive. There also is a strong correlation between detention and torture. Rebel groups detain individuals and then torture them for information or to send a clear message to their opponents. Another strong relationship is between killings and detention. Detention and killings are among the most common human rights violations committed by rebel groups. The weakest relationship is between movement restrictions and sexual violence.

Table 2: Polychoric Correlations

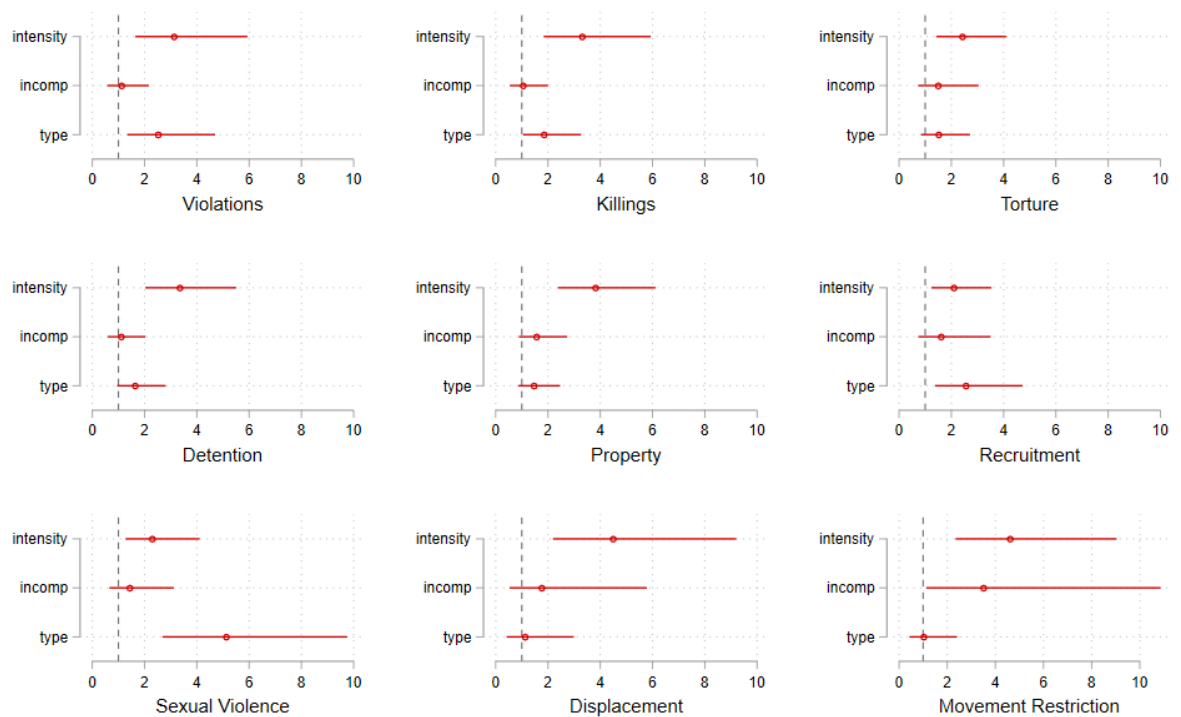
	Killings	Torture	Detention	Property	Recruitment	Sexual	Displace	Restrict
Killings	1.00							
Torture	0.79	1.00						
Detention	0.80	0.85	1.00					
Property	0.76	0.73	0.72	1.00				
Recruitment	0.65	0.79	0.74	0.65	1.00			
Sexual	0.72	0.93	0.75	0.67	0.77	1.00		
Displace	0.70	0.65	0.64	0.54	0.55	0.52	1.00	
Restrict	0.62	0.62	0.68	0.54	0.67	0.43	0.75	1.00

Figure 5 summarizes the relationships between three conflict characteristics and rebel human rights violations. Each plot presents the results of a statistical model in which the occurrence of the human rights violation is the dependent variable, with a value of “0” for no allegations of the violation and a value of “1” if the dataset records that the violation was either infrequently or systematically committed by the rebel group (“1” or “2” in the above coding scheme). The estimation technique is fixed-effects logistic regression. Using explanatory variables from the Uppsala Conflict Data Program (Harbom, Melander and Wallensteen, 2008), we test if the occurrence of each violation is related to conflict intensity, the incompatibility between the government and rebels, and if the conflict is internationalized. Intensity can take two values: minor armed conflict that produces fewer than 1000 battle deaths in a year, or war, which produces more fatalities. Incompatibility measures if the conflict was over territory or control of the national government.⁶ A conflict is internationalized if one or more foreign states intervened with military forces. Figure 5 reports the odds ratios of the relationships between these three variables and each rebel human rights violation. The most consistent relationship is between

⁶ We drop two observations in which the incompatibility concerned both territory and government.

intensity and abuses; conflicts that are more intense, are more likely to involve all eight types of rebel human rights violations. In contrast, the type of incompatibility is not related to rebel human rights abuses. Conflicts over control of the government are no more likely than territorial conflicts to be associated with such violations with one exception: rebels are more likely to restrict movement when seeking to control the government. Internationalization of the conflict is associated with more rebel killings, forced recruitment, and sexual violence.

Figure 5: Intensity, Incompatabilities, and Internationalization



Patterns and Illustrations

Rebels commit a range of human rights violations, but the extent of such abuses varies across space and time. A closer examination of the dataset reveals several interesting patterns. First, there is significant variation among countries, with civilians in some experiencing more frequent and systematic abuse by rebels than those elsewhere. Violations have been consistently

high in countries with multiple rebel groups, each engaging frequently in numerous forms of abuse. These include Bosnia-Herzegovina (1992-1995), Colombia (especially 1998-2012), Uganda (1996-2011), Sierra Leone (especially 1993-2001), and Liberia (1990, 2001-2003). Such violations have been surprisingly low in other countries, though, despite multiple rebellions. Of the 35 annual observations for 16 rebel groups in Chad, just three show evidence of any violations.

Even within countries facing multiple rebellions, there is variation in abuses among rebel groups. In Afghanistan, Angola, India, Iraq, Pakistan, Rwanda, Somalia, and Sudan, at least one rebel group has been involved in systematic violations while others have been involved in few to none. A good example is the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC), where 14 groups waged armed rebellions against the government between 1990 and 2018. For eight of these groups, there is no evidence that they engaged in any violations. Two other groups engaged systematically in just one of the violations: AFDL committed frequent unlawful killings and Kata Katanga forcibly recruited troops in one year. The remaining four groups (CNDP, RCD, M23, and Kamuina Nsapu) engaged systematically in multiple violations. Two other rebel groups fighting against governments of neighboring countries (the Democratic Forces for the Liberation of Rwanda-FDLR and the Lord's Resistance Army of Uganda) also operated in eastern Congo and systematically committed a wide range of human rights abuses. Thus, even in a country that has become notorious for civilian abuse during conflict (Autesserre, 2012), there is variation in the extent to which individual rebel groups have engaged in such violations.

Patterns of civilian abuse change over time. In most cases, the frequency of human rights violations increases over the lifespan of a group. This was true for the Revolutionary Armed

Forces of Colombia (FARC), whose troops committed occasional unlawful killings for the first few years in the dataset (1990-1992). Such killings became more frequent starting in 1993, and the group's commission of other forms of civilian abuse also started to rise. By 1998, FARC soldiers were engaging systematically in all human rights violations coded in the dataset. In Burundi, the Palipehutu-National Forces of Liberation (FNL) committed few human rights abuses from 1997 to 2000. Starting in 2001, however, its forces engaged occasionally in unlawful killings and property violations; by 2004, they were frequently committing all human rights violations in our dataset. There is evidence of similar upward trends for the National Union for the Total Independence of Angola (UNITA), Sierra Leone's Revolutionary United Front (RUF), Hamas, and the Communist Party of India (Maoist). In some cases, however, the frequency of reported human rights violations declined over time: Peru's Sendero Luminoso (Shining Path), the Armed Islamic Group of Algeria (GIA), and the Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK) in Turkey.

Finally, rebel groups have different "repertoires of violence" (Hoover Green, 2016; Tilly, 2010). Most groups that engage in one form of human rights violation also engage in others. For several groups, there is evidence of systematic engagement in multiple abuses. These include: the Taliban in Afghanistan, the Serbian Republic of Bosnia-Herzegovina, the Mozambican National Resistance (RENAMO), the Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist Centre), Al Shabaab in Somalia, Sri Lanka's Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), and the Sudanese People's Liberation Movement/Army (SPLM/A). Other rebel groups seem to specialize, however, systematically engaging in one or two forms of civilian abuse while avoiding others. Al Qaeda in the Islamic Maghreb (AQIM) systematically killed and detained civilians, but shows no evidence

of other abuses. Similarly, several groups in India and Thailand have engaged in frequent killings and property violations but no other abuses. For other rebel groups, it is impossible to discern a specific repertoire of violence. In general, there is widespread variation in how rebel groups treat civilian populations, and future research can use the RHRV dataset to investigate these patterns.

Conclusion

In the effort to understand and explain the treatment of civilians by rebels, most research has focused on indiscriminate killings and, more recently, sexual violence. This emphasis is influenced by data availability. Using the RHRV dataset, researchers can develop a more nuanced understanding of how rebels treat civilians, including not just killings and sexual violence, but also torture, detention, forcible recruitment, property violations, forced displacement, and restrictions on movement. What factors influence the extent to which rebels commit different human rights abuses? If a rebel group uses one form of violation, is it more likely to use another? Do groups use some forms of abuse more strategically or systematically than others? How do military capabilities, funding streams, and battlefield dynamics influence the extent to which rebels commit different human rights violations? And how do such violations affect the ability of rebel groups to govern and hold authority in areas they control? In addition to facilitating quantitative research on such topics, the dataset includes textual excerpts from the source material that can be searched and further analyzed.

Policymakers should also be interested in understanding variations in the treatment of civilians by rebel groups. Conflict resolution resources may be better directed toward situations in which armed groups are committing abuses systematically to prioritize the resolution of

conflicts that cause the greatest human suffering. Of course, there are various factors that motivate international attempts at conflict resolution, including geopolitics, strategic concerns, media visibility, and domestic political pressure. With the development of a more systematic approach to collecting data on rebel human rights violations, such evidence can help inform and mobilize efforts to find peaceful resolutions to violent conflicts.

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